the subsequent border agreement with Burma that was signed in Peking in October 1960, the Chinese government accepted the portion of the same McMahon Line—nearly 200 kilometres—that separated Tibet from Burma.

The map attached to the Simla Convention had been initialled by the British representative, Henry McMahon, and signed by the Chinese delegate, Chen I-fan and the chief Tibetan representative, the Lonchen Shatra, on 27 April 1914. However, almost immediately, China refused to ratify the convention. At that stage, both the British and the Tibetan governments agreed that the refusal precluded China from enjoying any of the rights it had been granted in Outer Tibet, and that the agreement would be binding on the British and Tibetan governments.

The most significant factor that needs to be understood is that the Simla Convention of 1914 merely formalized what had in effect been the traditional boundary between the territories of India and Tibet (other than Tawang). It was a recognized and long-established boundary that was not ‘created’, but only confirmed by treaty. If anything, Captain Morshead had provided the scientific data while Captain Bailey had provided the cultural and demographic information to support the validity of the established frontier. The local authorities and inhabitants of the area as well as the governments of the two sides had for centuries recognized the validity of this boundary alignment, and even the People’s Government of China, after they established their control in Tibet, proceeded on the basis that this was indeed the boundary. The same watershed boundary represented by the McMahon Line of 1914 also held good for Bhutan, Sikkim, Nepal, Kumaon, Garhwal and Kinnaur extending up to the Sutlej River. The frontier beyond the Sutlej was also reasonably well established at the time: Lahaul, Ladakh and the Aksai Chin extending up to the Karakorams.

The British hesitation, apart from the reasons listed earlier, to go public with the details of the Simla Convention after 1914 can also be understood. There was still a huge gap on the ground between the administered part of Assam and the McMahon Line. The Mishmis and the Abors had only recently started allowing survey parties through their territories, but for all practical purposes remained uninitiated to modern governance. To the west were the Gallongs, Minyongs, Boris, Daflas, Akas and Sherdukpens, who were also part of the NEFT (later NEFA) area. Besides, almost immediately, World War I had erupted in Europe, resulting in the weakening of the